Today
Welcome to your next lesson: The power of the crowd.

I'm getting your personalized lesson ready — based on what you've learned, what's ahead, and how you learn best.

Step by step, you're moving forward.

Imagine you're at a packed concert or stadium 🏟

People start shouting, pushing forward, maybe even jumping fences. Some of those same people, alone, would never act that wild.

That's the puzzle in this lesson:

Why do "normal" people sometimes act very differently in a crowd — especially when they feel anonymous or hidden?

We're going to look at that using:

Le Bon's idea of the crowd mind
Zimbardo's research on deindividuation (losing your sense of individual self)
Quick gut check to start:

When you think about crowds (sports riots, big protests, crazy Black Friday lines, online mobs), which feels most true to you right now?

A) People in crowds reveal who they "really" are inside

B) People in crowds get swept up and act differently than they normally would

C) Crowds don't really change people much; it just looks more intense

D) Not sure yet

Just tell me the letter, and we'll build from there 👇

b

Nice, B is very close to how psychologists think about this too 👍

Let's zoom in on one early idea about this: Le Bon's "crowd mind."

Le Bon noticed that when people are in large crowds (think: stadium, protest, mob), three things often happen:

Individuality shrinks
You feel less like "Ron, with my usual standards" and more like "one of the crowd."

Emotions spread fast (contagion)
If a few people get angry, excited, or scared, that emotion spreads through the group like a virus 😱

Suggestibility goes up
People become more open to following simple, strong suggestions ("Let's push the barrier!") without thinking as carefully as they normally would.

So in a crowd, your usual filters (Is this smart? Is this right? Is this "me"?) get weaker, and the shared crowd emotion gets stronger. That's the basic idea of the crowd mind.

Does this match anything you've seen in real life (sports, concerts, church, protests, school, online)?

You can just say "yeah, like [short example]" or "not really sure yet."

Yeah, I've seen this

Perfect. Let's use that and go one small step deeper 🔍

Le Bon would say: in those moments you saw, the crowd's "shared mind" was steering people more than their individual minds.

Visually, think of it like this:

Alone:
"Me" → my values, my usual behavior, my self-control

In a crowd:
"Me" gets smaller, "We" (the crowd emotion + momentum) gets bigger

So your identity shifts a bit from I to we, and that "we" can push you toward actions you might not choose alone.

Make sense so far if I say:

In a crowd, people are more driven by shared emotion and less by their usual personal brakes?

If yes, I'll connect this to anonymity next (feeling hidden) and how that supercharges this effect 🔋

Yes, that makes sense

Awesome. Now let's bring anonymity into the picture 👤➡️👥

Think of two versions of you at a heated game:

Version 1: Fully visible
You're in a small section, lights are on, no mask, people around know your name. If you screamed insults or threw something, others could easily say, "Ron did that."

Version 2: Hidden/anonymous
You're in a huge, dark crowd, maybe with a hood or mask, nobody knows you, cameras can't really pick you out. If you did the same thing, it'd be hard to trace it back to you.

Psychology finds that in Version 2, people are more likely to:

shout more extreme things
break rules
follow the wildest parts of the crowd

Not because they suddenly became bad people, but because:

"I won't be singled out or held responsible" → less self-control + more crowd-driven

behavior

That’s the core idea we’ll connect to Zimbardo’s work next (deindividuation).

Before I show you that experiment, does this simple rule feel right to you?

The more anonymous I feel, the easier it is to go along with impulses and the crowd.

Yes / no / “kinda but…”?

Yes, that seems right

Great. You’ve got the intuition — now I’ll link it to a key experiment.

Zimbardo (same psychologist as the Stanford Prison Study) ran a study on something called deindividuation — basically what happens when people lose their sense of individual identity and feel anonymous.

Very simple setup, simplified:

Group A: Women wore normal clothes with name tags
Group B: Women wore big hoods and no names (faces harder to see, more anonymous)

Both groups were told to deliver “shocks” to another person as part of a learning task.

Result: the hooded, anonymous group gave stronger and longer shocks.

Same type of people. Same task.

The big difference? How identifiable they felt.

Psychologists call that state:

Deindividuation = feeling less like a distinct individual (with a name, face, and accountability) and more like an anonymous part of a group, which can weaken normal restraints.

So tying it together:

Le Bon: crowds → shared emotion + suggestibility
Zimbardo: anonymity → weaker self-awareness + weaker fear of being judged → more extreme behavior

Does the idea of deindividuation make sense with that experiment, or should I rephrase it one more time in even simpler terms?

makes sense\

Nice. You’ve now seen:

Crowds can shift us from “I” to “we.”
Anonymity can weaken “this is on me” feelings.

Now let’s zoom in on why anonymity is so powerful, step by step 🫣

Think of three “dials” in your mind:

Self-awareness: “I’m watching myself. Is this who I want to be?”
Fear of evaluation: “Others can see me and judge me.”
Accountability: “If I do this, I will get blamed.”

When you’re anonymous (hood, mask, big crowd, random username online):

Self-awareness dial turns down
Fear of evaluation turns down
Accountability turns down

With those dials lower, impulses and crowd emotions get louder and easier to act on (shouting, insulting, vandalizing, dogpiling online, etc.).

So it’s not that “I became a different person,” it’s that the situation changed which parts of me were in control.

Want to do a quick one-question check on which situational cue most strongly triggers this “deindividuated” state?

If yes, I’ll give you a small multiple choice question next.

Yes, let's try it

What do you think? 👇

Which situational cue is most likely to trigger deindividuation (people feeling less like individuals and more anonymous, leading to disinhibited behavior)?

A.

Being hard to identify (faces covered, no names, big crowd)

B.

Having a very important task to do

C.

Having a clear authority figure present

D.

Being in a small, well-lit group where everyone knows each other

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Take your time with the question below 👇

Which situational cue is most directly linked to deindividuation (people feeling less like identifiable individuals and more like anonymous members of a crowd)?

A.

Feeling anonymous or hard to identify

B.

Being in a small group of close friends

C.

Doing an important, meaningful task

D.

Having a clear leader giving instructions

a

Nice effort jumping in on that one 👍

Let’s walk through the idea behind that question in plain terms (without worrying about the specific options):

When psychologists talk about what really triggers deindividuation, the strongest situational cue is:

How identifiable you are — can people clearly tell “Ron did this”?

If your name, face, and identity are obvious → you feel more accountable → you usually behave more cautiously.
If you’re just one of many, hidden by a hood, mask, uniform, big crowd, or a random username → you feel less personally exposed → deindividuation goes up.

So: anonymity / low identifiability is the key switch that changes behavior, both in Le Bon’s crowds and Zimbardo’s lab work.

Let’s make this personal for a second:

Imagine two versions of you posting online about a controversial topic:

Account 1: Real name, real photo, coworkers and family follow you
Account 2: Anonymous username, no real photo, strangers only

If you’re honest with yourself:

Would what you’re willing to say change even a little between 1 and 2?

You can answer with: “yes”, “no”, or “probably a bit”.

yes

That honest “yes” is exactly what this lesson is about 👌

Let’s tie everything together in one simple chain:

In a crowd (or big online group), you shift from “I” to “we.”
Anonymity (no name, hidden face, random username) lowers:
self-awareness
fear of judgement
sense that “this is on me”
With those brakes weaker, crowd emotion + impulses can drive behavior more:
harsher comments
riskier actions
going along with things you’d resist when clearly visible

So based on Le Bon and Zimbardo, we can say:

Anonymity changes behavior because it makes us feel less like a responsible individual and more like an unseen part of a crowd, which loosens our normal restraints.

I want to hear this in your words now, short and simple:

If a friend asked you, “Why does being anonymous make people act differently?”, how would you answer in 1–2 sentences?

it makes them act differently because they are blending with the ccrowd, going with the flow rather then acting on their own thught out judgement and also because they dont fear retribution for their actions as they arent easily recognizable

That’s an excellent summary, Ron — you nailed both key pieces:

Blending with the crowd / going with the flow → Le Bon’s crowd mind (shared emotion > individual judgment)
Not fearing retribution because you’re not recognizable → Zimbardo’s deindividuation (anonymity lowers accountability)

Put together, that shows clear mastery of the outcome:

Based on Le Bon and Zimbardo, explain why anonymity changes behavior ☑

From here, you’ve officially got what you need for this lesson 🎯

Want to wrap up this lesson and move to the next one, or would you like to dig a bit deeper (for example, apply this to social media, protests, or work situations) before we move on?

Let's move to the next lesson

Nice work today, Ron 🎓

Quick wrap-up in your own words (which were spot on):

In crowds, people blend into a “we”, emotions spread fast, and they become more suggestible (Le Bon’s crowd mind).
When people feel anonymous (no name, hidden face, random username), they:
feel less personally watched
fear less judgement or punishment
and can slip into deindividuation — acting more on crowd emotion and impulse (Zimbardo).
So anonymity changes behavior by shrinking “this is on me” and boosting “I’m just part of the crowd.”

As you go forward, a simple question to keep in your pocket:

“If my real name and face were clearly attached to this action/post right now, would I do or say it the same way?”

That one question is a powerful brake on crowd + anonymity effects 🚦

You’re all set for the next lesson.
When you’re ready, hit Next in Learn, and I’ll be there with you for the next step.